UX CASE STUDY · ENTERPRISE K–12 PLATFORM

Texas School District / Forms Project

Designing Under Pressure: Transforming Complexity Into Clarity

DISTRICT SIZE	PROJECT TYPE	YEAR
40,000+ Students	**Condition-of-Sale**	**2024**

PORTFOLIO CASE STUDY

TABLE OF CONTENTS

OVERVIEW / INTRO

When UX Became the Difference Between Winning and Losi

A condition-of-sale design challenge at enterprise scale

01

THE BUSINESS CONTEXT

A large Texas school district serving more than 40,000 students was evaluating the platform. One requirement had quickly become a critical condition of sale: the district needed a scalable way to manage highly complex online forms across schools, age groups, and family workflows.

The existing experience created significant operational friction. Forms were static, repetitive, and surfaced irrelevant questions to users. Administrators struggled with complexity. Families encountered unnecessary cognitive load. If the problem could not be solved effectively, the deal itself was at risk.

THE DOUBLE CHALLENGE

What made this project especially meaningful was that the challenge extended beyond interface design. The team itself had relatively low UX maturity, limited exposure to research-driven workflows, and little experience integrating UX into product strategy early in the process.

> → **This project became two things simultaneously: a complex product design initiative, and a UX maturity transformation effort — delivered under real business pressure.**

HERO METRICS

DISTRICT SIZE

40,000+ Students

One of the largest K–12 districts in Texas

PROJECT TYPE

Condition-of-Sale Initiative

Deal contingent on solving the forms problem

CORE FEATURE

Dynamic Online Forms Scoping

End-to-end adaptive form experience

UX SCOPE

End-to-End Design Leadership

Research through delivery — full ownership

ADDITIONAL INITIATIVE

Bulk Move Forms to New Family

High-demand operational workflow for administrators

EMPATHIZE

Beginning With Listening Instead of Solutions

90 days of immersive discovery before a single wireframe

02

THE LISTENING TOUR

Rather than jumping directly into wireframes or requirements, I started with a structured listening tour. Over approximately 90 days, I immersed myself in the full ecosystem surrounding the product — not only what users were struggling with, but why the organization had arrived at this point operationally.

Stakeholder Interviews
Understand district priorities, pain points, and operational constraints

Sales Conversations
Map the condition-of-sale requirements and business risk clearly

Customer Support Observations
Identify where form complexity generated the most tickets and friction

User Workflow Discussions
Follow actual enrollment journeys from family submission to admin processing

Internal Product Alignment
Calibrate UX direction against engineering feasibility and roadmap reality

KEY DISCOVERY THEMES

Irrelevant form steps
Users forced through questions that didn't apply to their situation

Workflow variation
District processes varied significantly across schools and student types

Manual administration
Admin tasks were heavily manual — no scalable automation in place

Unnecessary repetition
Families re-entered data that the system already held

Accumulated complexity
Years of layered requirements had compounded into an unmanageable experience

→ **Complexity was not caused by a single feature failure. It had accumulated gradually through years of layered requirements and reactive product decisions.**

STAKEHOLDER ECOSYSTEM MAP

District Administrators	Efficient enrollment workflows — reduced manual burden	High
Families	Simplified, relevant form completion — less cognitive effort	High
Sales Teams	Condition-of-sale success — deal closure depends on this feature	High
Product Managers	Feasible implementation scope — technically achievable solution	High
Engineering	Clear conditional logic requirements — unambiguous design specs	High
Customer Support	Reduced confusion and inbound support tickets	Medium

USER PERSONA

USER PERSONA

L

Lisa

District Enrollment Administrator

K-12 District · 40,000+ Students

Lisa manages enrollment for thousands of students across a large Texas district. During peak periods, operational friction becomes a direct compliance risk.

GOALS

- Reduce manual processing & support burden
- Manage enrollment across schools efficiently
- Have forms adapt to district-specific rules

FRUSTRATIONS

- Static forms surface irrelevant questions
- Duplicate workflows waste team time
- No way to bulk-manage student transfers

BEHAVIOURS

- Escalates admin friction to product teams
- Builds manual workarounds to fill gaps
- Tracks support tickets caused by form errors

"The more confusing the forms are, the more support requests we receive."

ATOMIC UX RESEARCH FRAMEWORK

Structuring Research Into Actionable Decisions

As discovery findings accumulated, I used the Atomic UX Research framework to organise observations into actionable product direction — helping stakeholders move beyond isolated user comments toward structured decision-making grounded in patterns and operational impact.

EXPERIMENT	FACT	INSIGHT	RECOMMENDATION
Stakeholder interviews across districts	Districts manage forms differently by age group and school	Static forms cannot scale across varied district operations	Introduce dynamic scoping logic driven by student data
User testing on live form flows	Families skipped irrelevant sections or abandoned flows	Cognitive overload reducing completion confidence	Reduce visible steps contextually based on user profile
Support ticket analysis	Duplicate forms significantly increased administrative effort	Existing workflows create compounding operational inefficiency	Build bulk move functionality for family transfer scenarios

DEFINE

Identifying the Real Problem Beneath the Interface

From surface friction to structural complexity

03

THE REAL PROBLEM

The issue was not simply that forms were difficult to use. The deeper issue was that the system treated every user as if they needed the same experience — regardless of age, school, student type, enrollment scenario, or district rules.

→ **Users were forced through irrelevant workflows because the system lacked contextual intelligence. The opportunity was designing a dynamic experience that adapts to each user's specific conditions.**

At the same time, an organisational challenge ran alongside the product problem. Because UX maturity was still developing, I intentionally structured collaboration sessions to introduce whiteboarding practices, journey mapping, collaborative ideation, research synthesis, and prototype validation.

CURRENT VS FUTURE STATE

CURRENT STATE	FUTURE STATE
Static forms — same path for every user	Dynamic contextual flows — personalised per student
Irrelevant questions surfaced to all users	Only relevant questions shown based on context
Manual administration workflows	Streamlined processes with bulk management tools
High cognitive load — too many steps	Simplified experience — 4–6 contextual steps
Reactive support burden from confused users	Reduced confusion — fewer inbound support tickets

IDEATE

Simplifying Complexity Through Contextual Logic

Making complexity invisible to users

04

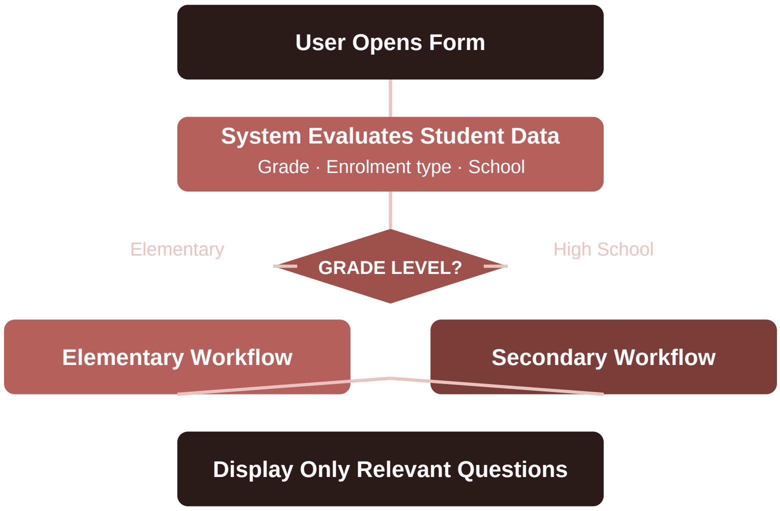
SYSTEMS THINKING APPROACH

This phase focused heavily on systems thinking. Rather than designing isolated screens, I explored how the platform could use existing student and district data to dynamically shape form experiences in real time.

I facilitated collaborative whiteboarding sessions with stakeholders, product, and engineering to map potential logic flows and identify operational edge cases. Contextual variables included student grade level, enrollment type, school-specific requirements, family structure, and existing system records.

> ↑ **The goal was not simply reducing steps visually. The goal was making complexity invisible to users — balancing district flexibility, family simplicity, and platform scalability.**

CONDITIONAL LOGIC DIAGRAM



Result: Reduced Completion Time + Lower Cognitive Load

WHITEBOARDING & COLLABORATION METHODS

- **Journey Mapping** → Understand enrollment friction across family and admin touchpoints
- **Whiteboarding Sessions** → Explore conditional logic structures and edge case scenarios
- **Stakeholder Workshops** → Align district operational needs with platform capability
- **Prototype Walkthroughs** → Validate understanding before committing to build direction

Research Synthesis → Prioritise user pain points by frequency and operational severity

PROTOTYPE

Making Complexity Feel Effortless

Interactive prototypes as alignment and communication tools

05

WHAT THE PROTOTYPES DEMONSTRATED

Once the logic structure was defined, I translated flows into interactive prototypes. Because stakeholders had varying levels of UX familiarity, interactive prototypes became critical communication tools — allowing teams to experience the solution rather than interpret static documentation.

Dynamic Form Branching
Forms adapt in real time based on evaluated student and district data

Reduced Step Counts
Irrelevant sections suppressed — families see only what applies to them

Simplified Navigation
Clear progression cues reduce disorientation and abandonment

Context-Aware Progression
Each step informed by the previous — no redundant re-entry

Administrative Workflows
Bulk move functionality built into the prototype for validation

Accessibility was integrated throughout — not treated as a separate track. Keyboard accessibility, semantic hierarchy, clear error handling, and reduced cognitive load were embedded directly into prototype decisions.

PROTOTYPE IMPACT COMPARISON

BEFORE	AFTER
10–15 potential form steps	**4–6 contextual steps**
Static, one-size-fits-all flow	**Adaptive workflow per user profile**
Repetitive form fields	**Personalised, pre-populated experience**
High user confusion	**Clear, predictable progression**

LEADERSHIP RECOGNITION

> *By embedding UX into the workflow rather than operating separately from it, the team became more engaged in user research, iterative design thinking, cross-functional collaboration, and validation before implementation. The result was not only a successful product outcome, but a stronger organisational understanding of how UX contributes strategically to product development.*

— Reflected in UX leadership feedback on cross-functional impact and organisational UX maturity contribution

---

UX MATURITY SHIFT

BEFORE

Reactive requests
Limited UX involvement
Solutions before research

→

AFTER

Research-driven collaboration
Embedded UX process
Validation before implementation

TEST

Iterating Through Validation and Feedback

Pausing, refining, and retesting over forcing solutions forward

06

WHAT TESTING REVEALED

Usability testing revealed important gaps that had not surfaced during earlier stakeholder discussions. Certain workflows still created confusion. Some assumptions about district processes needed refinement. Additional edge cases emerged around family structures and enrollment variations.

✓ **Rather than forcing the original solution forward, we paused, iterated, and retested. That willingness to continuously refine the experience became critical to the project's success.**

TESTING METHODS USED

Stakeholder Walkthroughs
Validate logic flows against real district operational needs

Usability Testing Sessions
Observe families navigating prototype tasks independently

Prototype Validation
Confirm conditional logic behaved correctly across scenarios

Workflow Reviews
Check administrative bulk-move flows with admin participants

Accessibility Evaluation
Verify keyboard navigation, screen reader support, and contrast

---

USABILITY FINDINGS SNAPSHOT

Users skipped form sections accidentally
Impact: High confusion — completion confidence dropped
Action: Added contextual progress indicators and step labelling

District workflows varied more widely than anticipated
Impact: Scalability concerns — original logic too rigid
Action: Expanded conditional logic to support additional enrollment variables

Families misunderstood key terminology
Impact: Increased inbound support burden from confused users
Action: Simplified content language; replaced jargon with plain-language labels

OUTCOMES & KEY LEARNINGS

Designing Systems That Reduce Complexity at Scale

Condition-of-sale delivered — and more

07

SUMMARY OF IMPACT

The project successfully delivered the condition-of-sale requirement while also improving internal collaboration and UX maturity across teams. Most importantly, the project demonstrated that UX leadership is not only about producing strong deliverables — it is about creating clarity within complexity.

DYNAMIC ONLINE FORMS SCOPING IMPLEMENTED

Condition-of-sale requirement met — deal successfully progressed

REDUCED COGNITIVE LOAD FOR FAMILIES

10–15 steps collapsed to 4–6 context-aware steps

STREAMLINED ADMIN WORKFLOWS

Bulk move functionality reduced manual processing overhead

UX EMBEDDED INTO TEAM PROCESSES

Research-driven collaboration became the operational norm

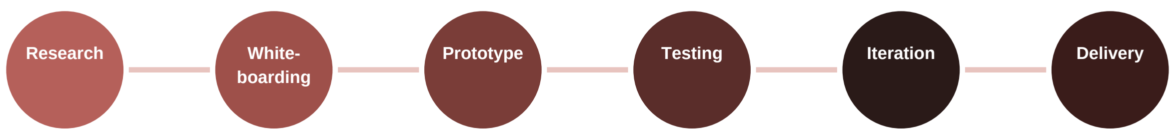
ACCESSIBILITY INTEGRATED THROUGHOUT

Not a separate track — woven into every prototype decision

CROSS-FUNCTIONAL COLLABORATION IMPROVED

Design, engineering, product, and sales aligned around user outcomes

CONTINUOUS UX LOOP



KEY LEARNINGS

- → **Listen before you design — the 90-day discovery investment prevented months of redesign. Understanding the system that generates problems is always faster than fixing the problems themselves.**
- → **Conditional logic is a UX tool, not just an engineering one — designing the decision rules that shape what users see is as important as designing the screens themselves.**
- → **Elevating team capability is part of the deliverable — embedding UX process into a team that hadn't yet operationalized it created lasting organizational improvement that outlasted the project.**
- → **Business pressure and UX rigour are not opposites — the condition-of-sale urgency made research more important, not less. Understanding the problem precisely was what made the solution fast.**
- → **Strong UX leadership is measured by the systems it leaves behind — not just the interfaces delivered, but the collaboration patterns, shared language, and organisational behaviors that persist because UX became part of how the team works.**

Strong UX leadership is not measured only by the interfaces delivered. It is measured by the systems, collaboration patterns, and organisational behaviors that improve because UX became part of how the team works.

UX Case Study · Texas School District / Forms Project · 2024